In 1660, Frenchman François Bernier, a medical doctor in Aurangzeb's court, visited this 'general school of the Gentiles [Hindus]' set 'in the midst of an extremely fine and rich country'. In a letter to a friend, Bernier calls Varanasi the 'Athens of India, wither resort the *Brahmens* and other devotees, who are the only persons who apply their minds to study. The town contains no colleges or regular classes, as in our universities, but resembles rather the schools of the ancients'.[24] Bernier writes about 'a large hall . . . entirely filled' with books on 'philosophy, works on medicine written in verse, and many other kinds of books'. He describes Varanasi's guru-disciple model of schooling, with four to fifteen disciples per guru, who met 'in private houses, and principally in the gardens of the suburbs, which the rich merchants permit them to occupy'.

Most pupils, Bernier writes, had 'an indolent disposition, owing, in great measure, to their diet and the heat of the country'. 'Feeling no spirit of emulation, and entertaining no hope that honors or emoluments may be the reward of extraordinary attainments, as with us, the scholars pursue their study slowly, and without much to distract their attention, while eating their *kichery*, a mingled mess of vegetables supplied to them by the care of rich merchants of the place.'[25]

The first thing they're taught, he writes, is Sanskrit, 'a language known only to the *Pendets*, and totally different from that which is ordinarily spoken in *Hindoustan*'. Their 'scientific books' are all in Sanskrit, he notes, but it 'has long become a dead language, understood only by the learned'. (Indeed, under the Mughals, state administration and literary production in royal courts happened in Persian and vernacular tongues like Braj and Awadhi. Under the British, Persian would suffer the same fate as Sanskrit, and make room for the rise of modern Hindi, Urdu and English.)[26]

Another Frenchman, Jean Baptiste Tavernier, who passed by in the 1660s, writes that Ganga water is highly esteemed in the country and people carry it on their shoulders over long distances. 'The principal reason why this water of the Ganges is so highly esteemed,' he writes, 'is that it never becomes bad, and engenders no vermin; but I do not know whether we should believe what is said about this, taking into consideration the number of [dead human] bodies which are constantly being thrown into the